The Data Behind
What Happens When Every Analyst Agrees?

Supporting evidence for a cross-analyst review of emerging technology, adoption and strategy.

Research scope	Gartner longitudinal dataset	Core question
Gartner, Forrester, McKinsey, IDC, Deloitte and the World Economic Forum	2016-2025 flagship Emerging Technologies cycles, assessed against 2026 adoption outcomes	Does analyst attention imply adoption, scale or value - and should every emerging technology immediately trigger a strategy?

Contents

The central finding

Analyst consensus is a visibility signal. It is not, on its own, evidence of widespread adoption, enterprise scale or repeatable value.

Prepared from the underlying evidence workbook. Figures described as "modelled" are analytical classifications, not statistics published by the research firms.

1. Ten years of Gartner data: most emerging technology does not become mainstream

Across the reconstructed 2016-2025 Gartner flagship Emerging Technologies Hype Cycles, the dataset contains 206 distinct technology labels. By 2026, only 40 are classified as mainstream in this analysis. That is 19.4%.

Measure	Result
Distinct technology labels	206
Classified mainstream by 2026	19.4%
Mainstream + specialist + absorbed	54.4%
First appeared at Innovation Trigger	68.4%

The 19.4% figure should not be read as an 80.6% failure rate. Another 41 technologies are classified as established specialist capabilities and 31 as absorbed or superseded. Together, mainstream + specialist + absorbed outcomes account for 112 of 206 technologies (54.4%).

The more important finding is that 141 of the 206 technologies (68.4%) first appeared at Gartner's Innovation Trigger - precisely when commercial adoption and proven value were least developed.

Implication: An emerging-technology signal often arrives before strategic certainty. The organisational response therefore needs to distinguish between awareness, experimentation and commitment.

Method note: "mainstream", "specialist" and "absorbed" are classifications from the supporting adoption model, calibrated against public evidence. They are not Gartner ratings.

2. Six research firms are not measuring the same thing

The cross-analyst comparison is useful precisely because the frameworks differ. Agreement across them increases confidence that a technology matters; it does not mean they are independently measuring the same adoption outcome.

Research firm	Framework	Primary lens	Adoption/value lens
Gartner	Hype Cycle	Expectations + maturity / proven value over time	Indirect; not a market-penetration measure
Forrester	Top Emerging Technologies	Expected benefit horizon	Some adoption evidence within individual write-ups
McKinsey	Technology Trends Outlook	Momentum: search, news, patents, research, investment, talent	Explicit adoption/scaling assessment
IDC	FutureScape	Time-bound enterprise predictions	Forecast-oriented rather than one maturity score
Deloitte	Tech Trends	Enterprise architecture and operating trends	Case-led, not standard adoption percentages
WEF	Top Emerging Technologies	Scientific progress + impact + ecosystem readiness	Readiness and impact horizon, not enterprise penetration

Cross-analyst convergence

AI / AI-related technologies appear across all six frameworks. Agentic AI / AI agents are explicitly foregrounded by at least four of the six in the 2025-2026 evidence set. Quantum technologies also recur across all six.

That convergence matters: it shows what is receiving sustained attention across independent research organisations. But it still does not answer whether every organisation should create a dedicated strategy for it.

3. AI demonstrates why visibility, adoption, scale and value must be separated

The 2026 McKinsey survey is particularly useful because it measures several stages of organisational engagement at once. The resulting gap is the point: broad usage can coexist with much lower enterprise scale and even lower repeatable financial impact.

Measure	2026 result	What it means
Regular AI use in >=1 business function	~89%	Usage is widespread
Scaling AI across the enterprise	44%	Enterprise integration is materially lower
Positive EBIT impact attributed to AI	37%	Financial impact is lower again
AI high performers	~6%	Only a small minority combine material EBIT impact with significant reported value
Individual productivity improved by AI	80%	Individual benefit can precede enterprise financial impact

Visibility -> Adoption -> Scale -> Value

Those are related stages, but they are not interchangeable. A technology can be highly visible and widely used while still being immature at enterprise scale. It can also scale without producing consistent financial value.

This is why an analyst headline should not be read as a strategy instruction. The strategic question is not simply "is this technology important?" but "what evidence would justify scaling it here?"

4. Different technologies produce very different outcomes

The longitudinal Gartner view shows that similar levels of early attention can lead to very different outcomes. Some technologies become infrastructure, some specialise, some are absorbed into other labels, and some remain long-horizon.

Technology	Gartner journey	2026 assessment	Interpretation
5G	2017 IT -> 2018 IT -> 2019 Peak	Established / mainstream	A technology that effectively became infrastructure.
Augmented Reality	2016 TD -> 2017 TD -> 2018 TD	Established / mainstream	A Trough example whose capabilities became embedded in products and specialist use cases.
Machine Learning	2016 Peak -> 2017 Peak	Established / mainstream	The label became increasingly embedded in software and analytics.
Generative AI	2020 IT -> 2021 IT -> 2023 Peak -> 2024 Trough	Established / mainstream use	Adoption continued even as expectations moved through the curve.
Blockchain	2016 IT -> 2017 Peak -> 2018 Peak	Established / specialist	Broad transformational expectations narrowed into specialist applications.
Metaverse	2022 IT	Hype cooled / niche	A highly visible label whose broad promise narrowed.
AI Agents	2025 Peak	Still emerging / evolving	A current case where analyst visibility is ahead of broad enterprise maturity.

The pattern is not "hype succeeds" or "hype fails". The pattern is that attention resolves into different forms of value - ubiquity, specialist use, absorption, delay or disappointment.

5. What the evidence means for strategy

The cross-analyst research changes the question. If multiple analyst firms agree that a technology matters, that is useful evidence that it deserves attention. It is not yet evidence that the correct organisational response is a dedicated multi-year strategy.

1. Signal: Understand why analysts believe technology matters.

2. Hypothesis: Define the business problem, value mechanism and conditions under which adoption would make sense.

3. Experiment: Test cheaply enough to learn before committing.

4. Evidence: Measure adoption, repeatability, economics, operational fit and value.

5. Strategy: Scale when the evidence justifies durable organisational commitment.

Consensus should create curiosity, not certainty.

Perhaps every emerging technology does not need a strategy. Perhaps it needs a hypothesis first - and a strategy only once the evidence begins to tell us what is actually worth scaling.

6. Methodology and source notes

Gartner longitudinal dataset. The supporting workbook reconstructs the flagship Gartner Emerging Technologies Hype Cycles for 2016-2025, preserving exact labels and annual phase placement. A separate adoption-maturity model assesses 2026 outcomes using public evidence. The model is explicitly separate from Gartner's own ratings.

Cross-analyst comparison. Research frameworks are preserved on their own terms rather than normalised into a false common score. The comparison asks what each framework signals: expectations, benefit horizon, momentum, prediction, enterprise trend or ecosystem readiness.

Interpretation caveat. Technologies enter the datasets at different times. A 2025 technology has had far less time to mature than one first identified in 2016. Therefore, the 19.4% mainstream figure reflects the current state, not a lifetime conversion probability.

Primary and supporting sources

Publisher	Publication	Link
Gartner	Hype Cycle for Emerging Technologies, 2026	https://www.gartner.com/en/documents/8163629
Forrester	Top 10 Emerging Technologies for 2025	https://www.forrester.com/press-newsroom/forrester-top-10-emerging-technologies-2025/
McKinsey	Technology Trends Outlook 2025	https://www.mckinsey.com/capabilities/tech-and-ai/our-insights/the-top-trends-in-tech/
McKinsey	The State of AI: Global Survey 2026	https://www.mckinsey.com/capabilities/quantumblack/our-insights/the-state-of-ai
Deloitte	Tech Trends 2025	https://www.deloitte.com/global/en/insights/topics/technology-management/tech-trends_new.html
World Economic Forum	Top 10 Emerging Technologies of 2025	https://www.weforum.org/publications/top-10-emerging-technologies-of-2025/
IDC / HPCwire	IDC FutureScape 2026 public coverage	https://www.hpcwire.com/off-the-wire/idc-futurescape-2026-predictions-reveal-the-rise-of-agentic-ai-and-a-turning-point-in-enterprise-transformation/

The full claim register, calculations, source notes, and the 206-technology longitudinal matrix are available in the companion evidence workbook.